

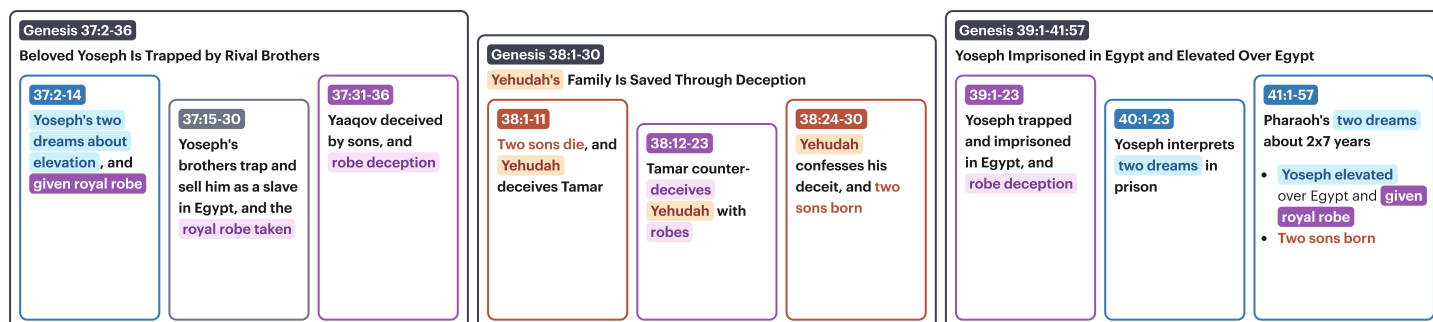
Session 4: A Tale of Two Seeds

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew word *toledot* translates to “generations,” and it serves as an important structural marker throughout Genesis as the story traces chosen and non-chosen family lines.
- Working out the implications of Genesis 3:15, the rest of the book prepares readers of the Hebrew Bible to be on the lookout for the chosen seed of the woman who will ultimately triumph over the snake.
- The Bible repeatedly subverts a cultural propensity toward ethnic exclusivity with the inclusion of members of the non-chosen family line in God’s plan to bring blessing to the whole world.

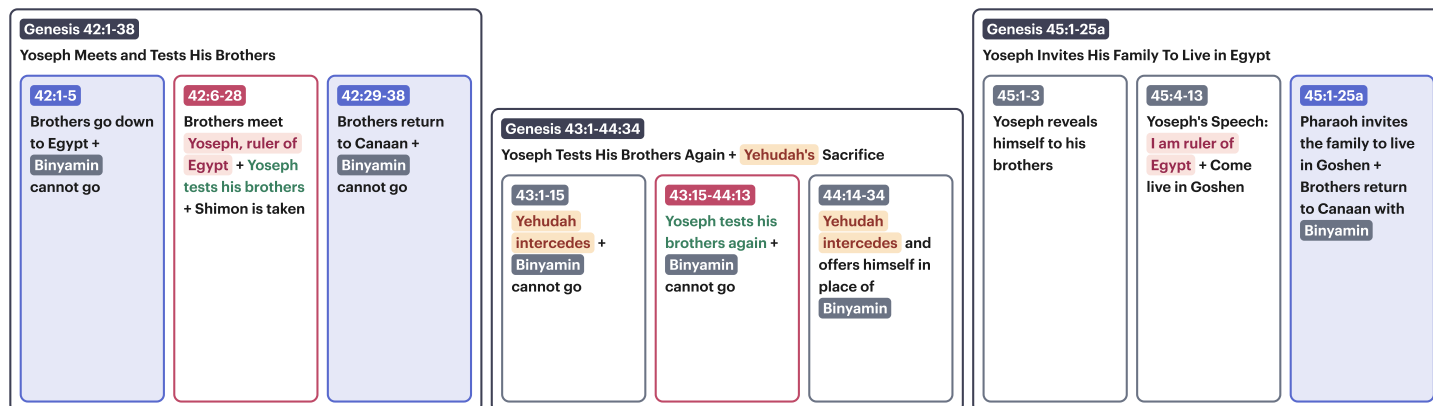
The Literary Design of the Yoseph Story: Genesis 37:2-50:26

Part 1: Genesis 37:2-41:57



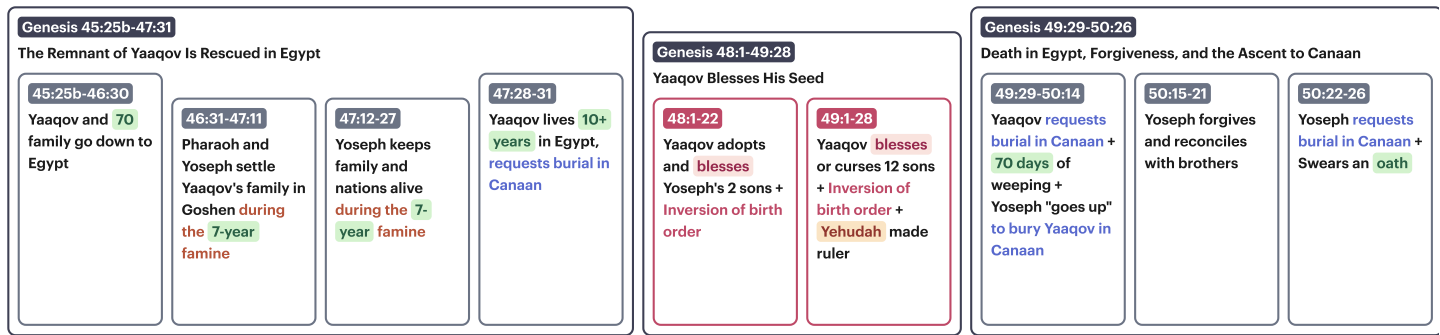
Genesis 37:2-41:57. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Part 2: Genesis 42:1-45:25a



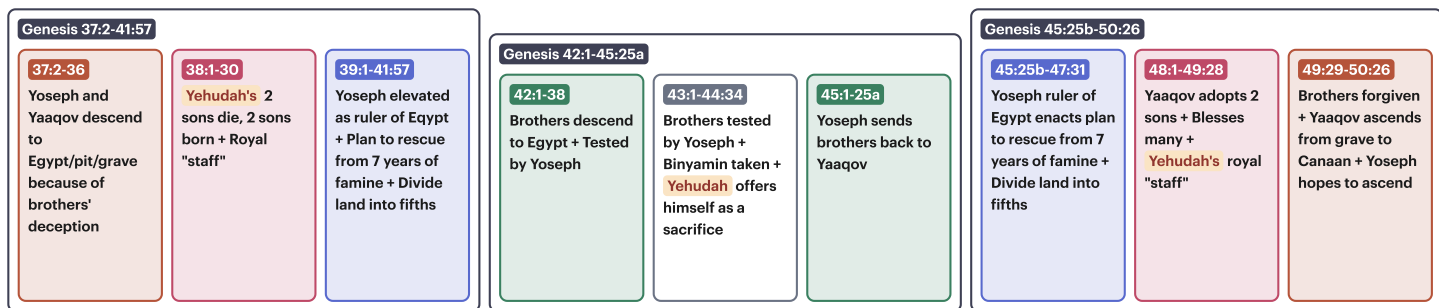
Genesis 42:1-45:25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Part 3: Genesis 45:25b-50:26



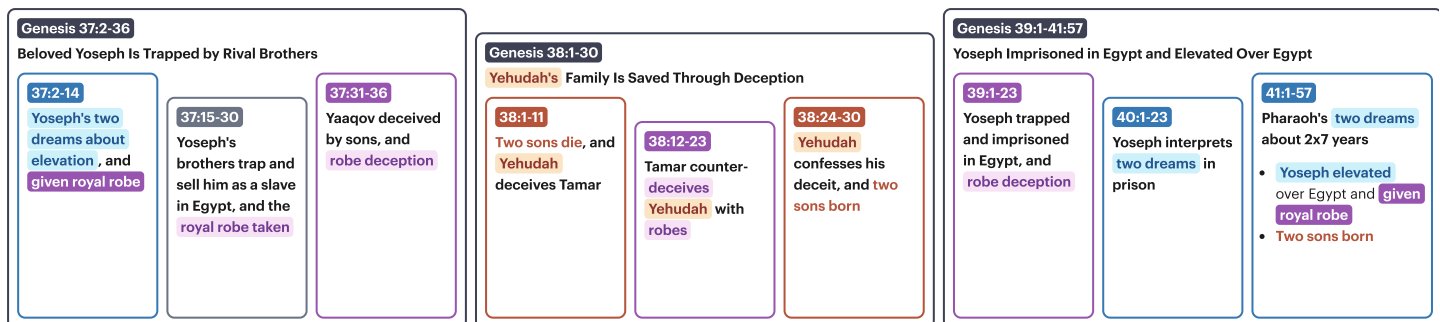
Genesis 45:25-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

When we zoom out to take in Genesis 37-50 as a whole, a new set of relationships present themselves.



Genesis 37:2-50:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Part 1: Yoseph's Descent and Ascent



Genesis 37:2-41:57. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This opening act of the Yoseph and Yehudah story is designed in a symmetrical way to show how the events set in motion by the brothers in chapter 37 are reversed and come full circle in chapter 41. The key plot conflict revolves around Yoseph's dreams of becoming ruler of the world and of his family (Gen. 37:2-14), and by the final scene of this act, those dreams start becoming reality (Gen. 41:1-57).

- Dreams: Yoseph's two dreams (ch. 37) // the two dreams of Pharaoh's servants (ch. 40) // the two dreams of Pharaoh that result in Yoseph's elevation as ruler (ch. 41)
- Robes: Yoseph is given a special robe that symbolizes his father's favoritism and also his dream of royal rule (ch. 37). That robe is taken away by his brothers and used to deceive Yaaqov (Gen. 37:31-36). // In the central story, Tamar the daughter also uses deceptive clothing to trick her father-in-law into having sex with her, in order to save his family's future (ch. 38). // Potiphar's wife also uses Yoseph's robe to

trick her husband (ch. 39). // Yoseph's royal robe is restored when he is elevated in Egypt in the restoration of his dreams (ch. 41).

- Deception: Yoseph is tricked and taken advantage of two times in this section, by his brothers (Gen. 37:15-30) and by Potiphar's wife (Gen. 39:1-23), both resulting in a series of descents: into a pit, then into Egypt, then into a prison which is later called a pit. // Yaaqov is deceived by his sons, who rob him of his favored son who is now believed to be dead (Gen. 37:33-35). // These two deceptions are mirrored by Tamar's deception that results in new life for Yehudah's family and reverses the deaths of the past.
- Death of the son: In chapter 37, Yaaqov loses the firstborn son of his beloved wife Rachel. // In chapter 38, Yehudah loses his two firstborn sons, only to have two new sons born to him through Tamar's deception. // In chapter 41, Yoseph, who is in Egypt because of his brothers' deception, gets married and has two sons.

The Puzzle of Genesis 38

The sordid story of Yehudah and Tamar in Genesis 38 may at first seem to be a digression from the main plotline of the Yoseph narrative. But this is only a surface-level impression. The core themes are deeply connected to the flow of Genesis 37-41 (royal rule, deception, robes, death of the son, future of the family), and the focus on Yehudah himself is anything but random. Yehudah is key to Yoseph's sale into slavery in chapter 17. And together with chapter 38, these stories form the counterpoint to the central role Yehudah will play in Act 2 (Gen. 42-45), specifically his humility and self-giving love when he offers his own life in the place of his brother Binyamin (Gen. 44:14-34).

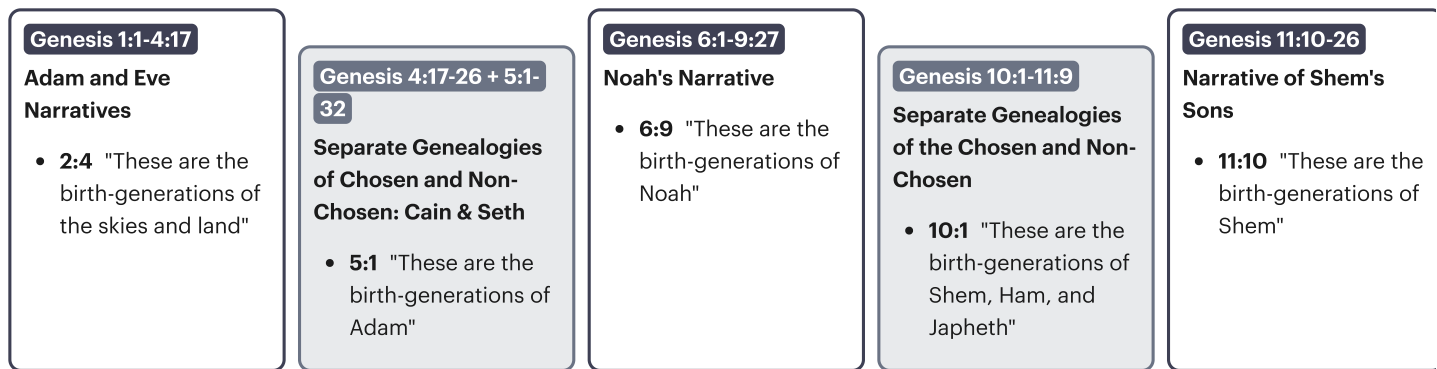
Section 1: Yoseph's Dreams and Hostile Brothers

Genesis 37:2a NASB

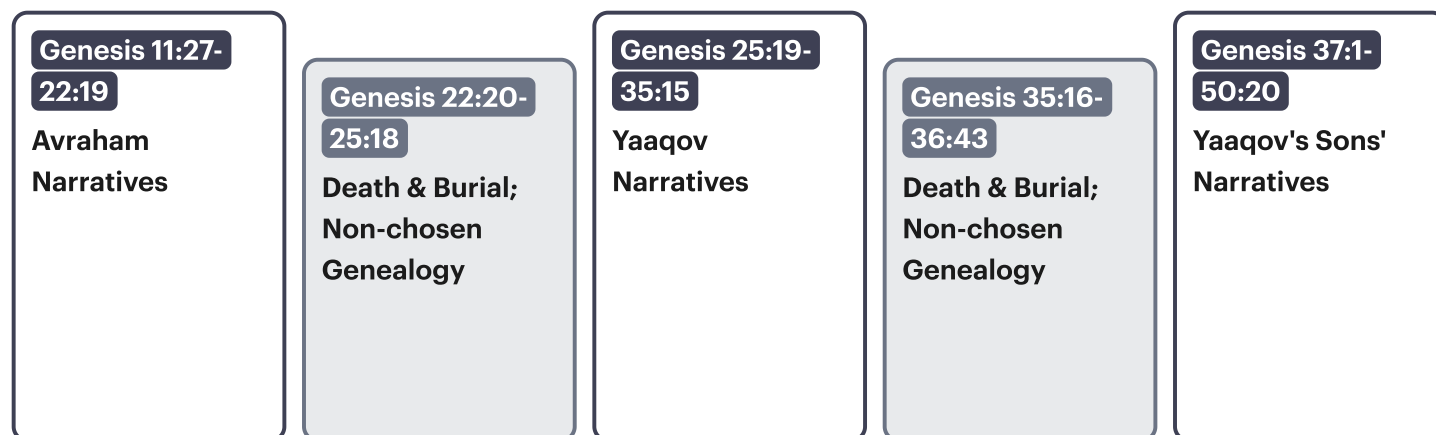
And these are the birth-generations of Yaaqov.

"Birth-generations" = Hebrew *toledot* / תולדות, which is a noun built from the root "to birth," meaning "the things that issued from" or "the things that were birthed from"

With this introductory phrase, the final literary movement of Genesis begins and ties this particular block of narratives into the wider themes of the entire scroll. This heading "These are the birth-generations of ..." appears 12 times in the Genesis scroll, six in Genesis 1:1-11:26, and six times in Genesis 11:27-50:26. In 10 of those 12 cases, the phrase has the same function, as it introduces the new descendants of each generation, one of whom will be singled out by God's blessing and election.

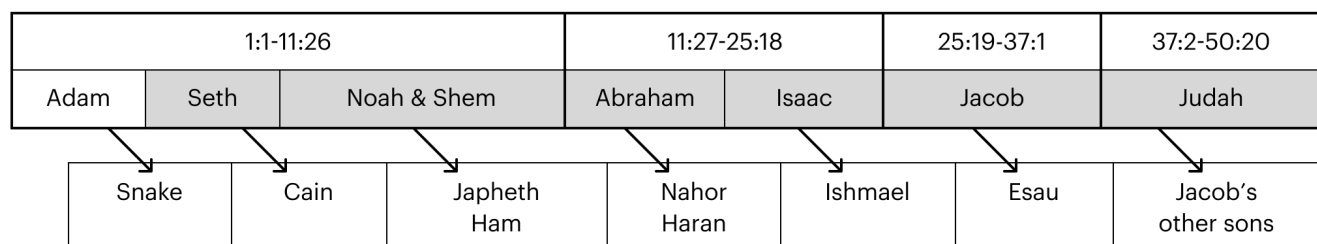


Genesis 1:1-11:26 (*Birth Generations*). Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).



Genesis 11:27-50:20. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

This pattern actually highlights an important compositional design throughout the entire Genesis scroll. The main narrative traces the lineage of the promised seed to a set of siblings. Then, after the story of their separation, the non-chosen line is ushered off the stage with a genealogy that extends far past the narrative time perspective. After this, the narrative backtracks and focuses on the chosen line, picking up their story.



Genealogies in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

"These transitional headings ... progressively direct the reader's focus from the progenitor to progeny and narrow the reader's focus from all the world to Israel, through whom all the families of the earth will be blessed."

DeRouchie, Jason (2013). "[*The Blessing-Commission, the Promised Offspring, and the Toledot Structure of Genesis*](#)". JETS, Volume 56.2. 225.

"The Genesis story moves from (1) the skies and the land ([1:1-2:3](#)) to (2) humanity ([2:4-4:26](#)) to (3) Noah ([5:1-6:8](#)) to (4) Shem ([11:10-26](#)) to (5) Terah ([11:27-25:11](#)) to (6) Yitzhak ([25:19-35:29](#)) and finally to (7) Ya'akov ([37:2-50:26](#)) ... The seven divisions move from larger to smaller unit until the readers arrive at the central vehicle through which God will accomplish redemption—the nation of Israel represented by its twelve patriarchs. The toledot structure ensures that the narrative does not wander aimlessly but focuses attention on the line of promise commissioned to carry out God's purposes in the world."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). [*Yoseph, Covenant, and Typology*](#). Tyndale Bulletin, Volume 69.1. 50.

This compositional design shows the narrator's focus on tracing the lineage of the chosen family. This obsession with a particular family line is rooted in the early Genesis narratives about humanity's calling to rule creation. Once that calling is forfeited, the promise narrows in on the seed of the woman ([Gen. 3:15-16](#)) who will undo what was lost in Eden. The design of Genesis shows that tracing the line of this promised seed is of ultimate importance to the author. And in the Yoseph story, that promise leads us to two prominent sons: Yoseph and Yehudah.

Reflection Question

How do the birth-generation cycles of Genesis inform the way we ought to think of our own stories within the scope of God's plan?